Vital signs ruler — adult (NEWS2 bands)

adult · ≥ 16 years, not pregnant · casualty / ward

Adult vitals · NEWS2 0–20

NEWS2 RULER — POINTS PER PARAMETER (0 green · 1 yellow · 2 orange · 3 red)

Resp rate /min	≤ 8 **3**	9–11 **1**	12–20 **0**	21–24 **2**	≥ 25 **3**
SpO₂ scale 1 %	≤ 91 **3**	92–93 **2**	94–95 **1**	≥ 96 **0**	
Air or O₂	Air **0**	Oxygen **2**			
Systolic BP mmHg	≤ 90 **3**	91–100 **2**	101–110 **1**	111–219 **0**	≥ 220 **3**
Pulse /min	≤ 40 **3**	41–50 **1**	51–90 **0**	91–110 **1**	111–130 **2**	≥ 131 **3**
Consciousness	Alert **0**	New confusion / V / P / U **3**			
Temperature °C	≤ 35.0 **3**	35.1–36.0 **1**	36.1–38.0 **0**	38.1–39.0 **1**	≥ 39.1 **2**

Scale 2 (target 88–92 %, e.g. COPD): 88–92 on air = 0; on O₂ ≥ 93 scores 1–3

PEARLS & PITFALLS

Score the trend, not one reading; recheck after each intervention
Beta-blockers mask tachycardia; elderly may not mount a fever
Count RR for a full 30–60 s — the most often missed sign

FORMULA

NEWS2 = sum of 7 parameters (0–20)

▸ **MAP**: (SBP + 2 × DBP) / 3 mmHg — aim > 65 in shock ✚
▸ **Shock index**: HR / SBP — > 1 = shocked (pulse > SBP) ✚
▸ **Pulse pressure**: SBP − DBP mmHg — narrow < 25 % of SBP

RESPONSE — NEWS2

- **0** Low — min 12-hourly obs
- **1–4** Low — min 4–6-hourly; nurse assesses
- **single 3** Any single 3 — hourly obs; urgent doctor review
- **5–6** Medium — hourly obs; urgent review, consider sepsis
- **7–20** High — continuous monitoring; emergency team, consider HC/ICU referral

RELATED

SpO₂: give oxygen if < 94 % ✚
Hypertension: SBP ≥ 140 and/or DBP ≥ 90 on 2 occasions ≥ 2 days apart ✚
Pregnancy: single SBP ≥ 160 and/or DBP ≥ 110 = acute severe hypertension → urgent management and referral ✚
Pregnancy: use the maternity early warning chart (EWC), not NEWS2 ✚
RR < 12 after sedation = respiratory depression → oxygen, prepare to ventilate ✚

NEWS2 Royal College of Physicians. National Early Warning Score (NEWS) 2, 2017 · **CLASSIC** classic teaching · ✚ **PHC** STG & EML Primary Healthcare 8th ed. 2024 (updated Sept 2026) — p. 4.15 · ✚ **HOSP** STG & EML Hospital Level Adults 6th ed. 2024 (updated Mar 2026) — p. 15.8, 20.12, 23.4 · ✚ **MAT24** National Integrated Maternal & Perinatal Care Guidelines for SA, 5th ed. 2024 — p. 52, 62, 103
✚ = SA STG / national guideline (pages in footer). Unmarked lines: the other sources listed. Checked against PocketDoc\Guidelines 2026-10-31. **Card** vitals-adult · updated 2026-10-31 · ANDH district level